

“I’ve been so sad about money, so I need to spend money to feel better,” she said. “I work five nights a week in a restaurant, so tell me I don’t deserve \$40 worth of sushi.” (She’s picked up a lot from Meme.) She paid her bills with my loan, but she also unabashedly set aside a little something-something for herself, and she wasn’t afraid to show it off on social media—where anyone, including her benefactor, might see it.

She then turned the tables: Maybe it’s *my* fault I feel money shame because I insisted on doing everything alone. (Damn. She’s good.)

Even with the same parents, it’s clear my younger sister and I were raised to have very different money scripts. I don’t want to throw all the shade on my sister. My parents certainly spent money on me too.

In a 2016 interview with my mom, I wondered out loud what would have changed about our money scripts if she and my dad had told us the truth about our family’s finances from the beginning. “Maybe I’m giving myself too much credit even though I was young and an asshole,” I said. But what if my mom had straight up said to us, “We cannot afford this.” What if they’d said no to my sister’s desire for new dresses or to my entitlement to sleepaway summer camps?

“I never would have done that,” my mom replied, aghast. She countered, asking me why I didn’t ask more questions at the time if I was so concerned. I said when I did, I was written off as “precocious” and like Cheyanne said, “paranoid.” (Being labeled “trying to be grown-up” by their families for expressing concern about money is an experience a few other young people interviewed for this book said they shared. We’re seen as “little adults” when our parents want our help and as “nosy kids” when they don’t.)

My sister and I lived in financial whiplash: sometimes our parents said yes to everything; sometimes they said no to things that made no sense. Our family’s money reality was a mystery to us and seemed to operate primarily on whims. We each took different money scripts from that, and it wasn’t until we sat down to discuss them with each other that we even got a peek at the full picture.

If you have siblings or cousins or anyone else around your age who grew up with you (or, hell, even friends who had similar households), talk to them about what they witnessed. Your money script is a puzzle, and other people hold most of the pieces. We don’t always remember events from our childhoods correctly,